Sometimes, the intensity of international cricket acts like a depth charge. A newly promoted player sustains his county form through a heady mixture of euphoria and adrenaline. Then reality is detonated. His faults are analysed by the opposition, the intensity of accountability builds, and confidence is hammered. Before he knows it, the international game has beaten him.

Sam Robson is a case in point. I was very impressed when I first saw him at close quarters. He was well organized, gutsy. He scored what was to be a solitary Test century in his second appearance against Sri Lanka in 2014 but was quickly worked out in the subsequent series against India by Bhuvneshwar Kumar, an English-style bowler who could swing the ball both ways.

That was puzzling, since Sam had faced similar bowlers, operating at around 80 or 81 mph, for Middlesex. Generally, new players are surprised by the extra pace and bounce of international cricket, since the ball in the county game comes through lower, between knee roll and hip, but he kept getting out in the same way. He was under pressure for his place on the winter tour in the last Test at the Oval.

I sensed him alongside me as we were going through final preparations on that glass-fronted dressing-room balcony. I looked out of the corner of my eye and saw, to my alarm, that he was transfixed by a TV screen along the corridor, which was showing his dismissals in sequence. It was almost as if his fate was sealed by auto-suggestion. He got out in familiar fashion and was unfortunately dropped.

My rudimentary understanding of my fear of failure was expanded by Bawds on an Ashes tour that began with the familiar ritual of a serious night out after getting off the plane in Perth. We had a couple of hours' sleep before, apart from Straussy – our captain and token grown-up – we reported for action at 6 p.m. The group straggled back to the hotel between 3 and 5 a.m.

Spare the sermons, because this was team bonding in its purest form. Without exception, we were running in the park at 11 a.m. that day. A snapshot from the session remains one of my favourite photographs; it is obvious we are hanging, but everyone is committed to putting the hard yards in. A cricket team isn't formed in a pub, but good habits and practices can be confirmed there.